

DULKEN'S DELUSION

Written by

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EXT. NETHERLANDS MEDICAL HELICOPTER - DAY

A MEDICAL HELICOPTER RACES through the sky with HIGH SPEED.

CUT TO:

INT. MARIA HOSPITAL INTERNAL MEDICINE ROOM 2C

Every room has white walls and a hospital bed with medical equipment around it. The doors are numbered with big clear numbers and letters.

JOHN (38, healthy, clean and neat) is standing beside a sad looking PATIENT 1 (44, bold, big head, scaly dry red skin, patient's gown) sitting on a hospital bed. Looking at John and the patient are doctors in lab coats surrounding the two, who are all at least 10 to 15 year John's seniors. At the door is ANGELA (36, black hair, confident) in nurse clothing.

JOHN

As you can see on the skin blisters
and the red hue on the skin, you
would diagnose the patient with
'Congenital ichthyosiform
erythroderma'.

The older doctors nod in agreement.

JOHN (CONT'D)

But, Mr. Janssen was not born with
any skin disorder. Which prompted
me and Angela to run some tests.

John walks to a screen, picturing an MRI-scan of a chest.

JOHN (CONT'D)

We ran blood tests, DNA tests, but
all came back negative. But when we
took an MRI-scan, I noticed this
dark spot right here.

John points at the patient's top right of the right lung where a miniscule black spot is, only visible to specialists.

JOHN (CONT'D)

This, this is an enlargement of the
lymph nodes. Which is a tell-tale
sign of Hodgkin lymphoma, cancer in
the Lymphocytes.

The doctors nod intrigued.

CUT TO:

EXT. NETHERLANDS MEDICAL HELICOPTER

PROPELLERS are SPINNING FAST, in the back a patient is ON OXYGEN and covered by a blanket.

CUT TO:

2

INT. MARIA HOSPITAL INTERNAL MEDICINE ROOM 2C

2

John walks back to patient 1.

JOHN

Spotting this abnormality in the lymph nodes prematurely, i.e. cancer in the white blood cells, the oncology department were right on time to start treatment.

John stands beside Patient 1 again.
Lays his hand on Patient 1's shoulder.

JOHN (CONT'D)

All revealing it was 'Ichthyosis acquisita', meaning that if the cancer is cured - which has a 98% of success -, Mr Janssen's skin disease will abate as well.

John smiles, a careful smile comes from Patient 1.

CUT TO:

EXT. MARIA HOSPITAL ROOFTOP

We see the Maria Academic Medical Centre. It's a giant building that towers above all other buildings.

The MEDICAL HELICOPTER LANDS on the helipad.

CUT TO:

INT. MARIA HOSPITAL INTERNAL MEDICINE FLOOR

We hear PATIENT GROANING, COUGHING, CONVERSATIONS, WHEELCHAIRS, HEARTMONITORS, medical CARTS on the Internal Medicine floor.

The senior doctors walk out of the room, DISCUSSING in great interest about the case. John and Angela walk out of the room as well. John is holding a medical chart.

JOHN
Angela, would you moisturize and
exfoliate Mr. Janssen's skin?

ANGELA
Yes

She agrees wholeheartedly.

JOHN
Great

John walks towards the counter of the internal medicine floor
in the Internal medicine floor.
Angela hangs in the door opening of the room 2C.

ANGELA
Mr. Janssen, I will be right back
with your daily moisturizing.

She walks the opposite way from John.

John is WRITING in the medical chart while leaning on the
desk.

(BANG)

The DOUBLE DOORS FLY OPEN with two male nurses and a PILOT
(44, black pilot suit, no helmet) RUNNING IN, PUSHING FORT a
STRETCHER with an unconscious patient. A nurse keeps a
NARCOSIS MASK against the patient's face. John quickly turns
around.

JOHN
4C!

John points in the direction of room 4C. The nurses turn the
way he's pointing. John RUNS along the fast riding squad, so
fast that he has to HOLD his STETHOSCOPE.

JOHN (CONT'D)
What is his condition?

PILOT
(stress)
The patient seems to have a
horrific infection that is growing
worse and worse!

JOHN
Infection, what kind of infection?

PILOT

(stress)

Unclear, that's why we brought him here for doctor Dulken to diagnose him. Could you send him here, quickly.

JOHN

I'm Dulken, John Dulken.

PILOT

(surprised)

Oh, great.

(beat)

(under breath)

I expected someone older.

The squad continues RUNNING to room 4C.

INT. MARIA HOSPITAL INTERNAL MEDICINE ROOM 4C

Medical equipment is already positioned besides the bed which is in the middle of the room.

(BANG)

The STRETCHER BLOWS through the DOORS.

JOHN

Put him on the bed and wash your hands and face immediately!

The nurses place the patient on the hospital bed and walk to the sink. The female nurse takes the NARCOSIS MASK off PATIENT SMITH (48, pale, nasty gashes on entire body, greying black hair, balding on a few places, hospital gown). Smith has ripped skin and bite marks, seeming to belong to a mammal. John is putting on RUBBER GLOVES while standing besides the Pilot. The female nurse is checking Smith's pulse.

JOHN (CONT'D)

Is it contagious?

PILOT

Not sure. We originally found him in his hut losing a lot of blood after a worried person informed us he was there. So we don't know much about it

John SIGHS out of frustration.
He STEPS FORWARD, but the Pilot GRABS his ARM.
John looks back in surprise.

PILOT (CONT'D)
Look out, he *bites*.

John turns back to the patient. At that moment, the patient eyes shoot open, and he looks directly at the nurse checking his pulse. He opens his mouth and his teeth show. He tries TO BITE HER, she SCREAMS. John runs at him and PUSHES HIM against the bed. The nurses who were washing their hands RUSH back and help to HOLD HIM DOWN.

PILOT (CONT'D)
He bites himself, you have to put him under!

The Patient comes loose and BITES his own FLESHY left ARM which is already covered with scars and bitemarks. John grabs the NARCOSIS MASK and PUSHES it on the mouth and nose of the possessed patient who is making ALMOST DEMONIC NOISES.

INT. MARIA HOSPITAL INTERNAL MEDICINE ROOM 4C - NIGHT

The room is covered in darkness besides a reading lamp. John is sitting besides the unconscious patient on a stool. He is reading a medical book.

ANGELA (O.S.)
Don't you have the morning shift tomorrow?

John turns around on his stool. Angela is standing in the doorway.

JOHN
Oh Angela, that's right. I *have* to speak to this patient.

ANGELA
Need help?

JOHN
No, no that won't be necessary. Plus I will be leaving soon, but thanks.

ANGELA
Okay, don't stay up too late.

Angela hides her worry under an unsure smile. John gives a fake smile. He turns back and examines the bite wounds.

SMITH (O.C.)
Do you have to speak to me?

John got startled for a second.

JOHN
You're awake?
(beat)
Yes, I have to speak to you.

Smith looks afraid.

JOHN (CONT'D)
Why do you have the sensation to
bite yourself?

John grabs a notepad. Smith lays a hand on his forehead.

SMITH
Did I do it again?
(beat)
I'm sorry!

JOHN
Don't be sorry, that is why you are
here.
(slow, empathetical)
So please, tell me why you bite
yourself?

SMITH
I-I don't know... It feels like my
skin is red hot, and all I can
think of is to bite it...

John makes a note.

JOHN
"Red hot", like in 'searing' or
'irritating'?

SMITH
Both.

JOHN
Both? Alright...

John WRITES it down.

SMITH
Excuse me doctor, doctor...?

JOHN
Dulken.

Smith reaches out to give John a hand, but John politely declines. Smith nods understandably.

SMITH
My name is Frank Smith.

JOHN
Nice to meet you, John Dulken.

SMITH
I am sorry doctor, but I'm dog tired, could I please go back to sleep?

JOHN
(confused)
Oh, well yeah, but I am trying to help you. The more information you provide to me, the faster I am able to diagnose you-.

SMITH
(curt)
-please.

John looks stymied.

JOHN
Excuse me, (coughs)
I will speak to you tomorrow.

SMITH
Thank you doctor.

John stands up from his CREAKING STOOL with a confused look, walks away with his notepad under his arm.

INT. MARIA HOSPITAL OFFICE JOHN DULKEN - MORNING

John has his own office with a desk. Medical books are spread on top of the desk with notes, pens between pages etc. Sunlight shines through the big industrial windows behind John who is asleep with his head laying on the desk.

JOHN'S PHONE RINGS. It wakes him and he searches between the many books. He finds it and ACCEPTS the CALL.

JANE (O.S.)
(phone)
Where are you, you didn't come home last night?

John rubs his eyes and leans on the desk.

JOHN

Jane? I am sorry honey, you know
work has been hectic the last few
days and-.

JANE (O.S.)

(phone, unpleased)

-.This is the fourth time this
week.

JOHN

I know.

But last night I was too tired to
drive home. So I decided to get
some extra work done...

Silence. John looks at his phone to check if the phone shut
off or not. He pulls the phone back to his ear.

JOHN (CONT'D)

Jane.-

JANE (O.S.)

(phone, curt)

-.When are you coming home?
We need to talk.

JOHN

My next shift starts in...

Checks watch.

JOHN (CONT'D)

Half an hour...

Silence.

Jane HANGS UP. John DROPS the PHONE on the DESK, defeated.
John rubs his face.

INT. MARIA HOSPITAL INTERNAL MEDICINE ROOM 4C

Besides the doors are two GUARDS (strong men, walkie-talkie
on belt). John is standing between them and patient Smith,
holding Smith's medical chart. Smith is sweating profusely.

JOHN

Noted.

John notes something in Smith's chart.

JOHN (CONT'D)

Say, mister Smith, do you have a
history of PTSD or depression?

Smith frowns, rubs sweat off his forehead.

SMITH

No, never.

John notices the sweat.

JOHN

I see that your sweat glands are acting up, does this happen often?

SMITH

Oh yeah, countless.

John NOTES it down with a sceptical look.

SMITH (CONT'D)

May I ask you something John?

JOHN

Of course you can *patient* Smith.

SMITH

Could I *please* go home...?

Smith's VOICE CRACKS.

JOHN

Uhm... Mister Smith... I'm sorry, but that is simply impossible.

SMITH

(emotional)
Why not?

John SIGHS SOFTLY.

JOHN

We have yet to find out what 'it' is you have. You are a danger to yourself and possibly to others. Your condition could be contagious. We can *not* take that risk.

Smith SIGHS, his eyes watery. He turns away, facing the window. Then immediately turns back to John.

SMITH

At the least, could you send away those *thugs*.

John turns back to look at the guards, turns back.

JOHN
They are here to protect you from
yourself.

Smith starts to SHAKE. HEARTMONITOR BEEPS FASTER.

SMITH
(childish)
I don't care for that, send them
away.

JOHN
(perplexed)
They are for your own safety...

Smith opens his mouth and shows his many teeth, tilts his
head up.

SMITH
(angry, a lot of saliva)
I don't want them here.

He opens his jaws and bends forward. With one fast CRUNCH, he
BITES off his own right MIDDLE FINGER and INDEX FINGER. The
BED is SHAKING and the GUARDS are SPRINTING towards the
patient. They desperately try to get the man off himself
while the HEARTMONITOR GOES BEZERK. John looks in fear and
GULPS.

INT. MARIA HOSPITAL INTERNAL MEDICINE ROOM 4C - NIGHT

Smith is under narcosis with bandages around his recently
bitten shoulder and hand. John is watching him while biting
his own fingernails. Doctor PETERS (54) of neurology stands
besides him.

PETERS
What is the diagnosis?

John looks at Peters and turns back to Smith.

JOHN
Unclear.

PETERS
Unclear? It's been *three weeks* and
the patient seems to be in critical
condition, there has to.-

JOHN
-.I Know.

Peters frowns.

PETERS
Has the patient been through
psychological testing?

John stares Peters down with a piercing stare.

JOHN
(curt)
Of course.

PETERS
...what was it?

JOHN
A waste of time, no irregularities
in his personality. Only a bit more
cynical than most people.

Looks back at Smith.

JOHN (CONT'D)
There is a overwhelming majority in
psychical symptoms, ergo an
infinitesimal small chance of the
cause to be psychological.

Peters looks defeated while Dulken looks determined and
angry.

JOHN (CONT'D)
You believe a person's brain wants
to eat himself, doctor Peters? A
organism's own limbic system is not
capable of doing that, it goes
against all its surviving
instincts.

John turns to Peters, clutching Smiths medical chart tightly.

JOHN (CONT'D)
(patronising)
But I appreciate your help doctor
Peters.

John gives Peters a PAT ON THE BACK and WALKS away.

INT. JOHNS HOME BEDROOM - MORNING

The sun shines through the cracks of the closed curtains on
the bed in the middle of the room. John lays in his bed wide
awake. The other side of the bed seems to be untouched and
made.

On top of John's nightstand is a lamp, medical book, pills, phone and picture frame. While the nightstand on the other end is empty.

ALARM CLOCK RINGS. John SLAPS the alarm OFF the same second.

INT. JOHNS HOME LIBRARY - EVENING

John has his own personal library filled with medical books. He is sitting with his back against a bookcase while sitting on the ground, reading a book, medical books spread around him. The clock on the wall reads 22:33. Also, a stack of boxes are visible labelled: 'Kitchen', 'bedroom', 'personal'.

John is a mess, his hair is scruffy, he's wearing a bathrobe over his shirt and underwear. He hasn't shaved in a few days and the acne on his face is visible.

John's MOBILE PHONE RINGS. He PICKS up and holds the book between his legs.

JOHN

Angela?

ANGELA

John, I know it's your off-day,
but Smith's test results are in.

JOHN

Outstanding, I will come right
away!

ANGELA

I-. (inaudible)

In Johns enthusiasm he hangs up, not hearing what Angela is saying. He SLAPS the book SHUT with his legs and JUMPS up with a smile on his face.

INT. JOHNS HOME BATHROOM

John is standing in front of his mirror, his smile has disappeared. We see the red acne covering his face. He rubs some ointment on the skin and continues to cover it up with make-up.

INT. MARIA HOSPITAL INTERNAL MEDICINE UNIT

Angela is standing behind the counter putting on her jacket. You can look in room 4C from the counter.

John RUNS in with his casual clothes, stopping besides the counter. He looks with a hopeful smile at Angela.

JOHN
(out of breath,
enthusiastic)
Angela, the test results.

Angela turns around surprised, but her look fades into a sad one.

ANGELA
The lab didn't find any
inconsistencies in his blood. He
seems to be perfectly healthy...

John leans on the counter, defeated. He BREATHES OUT HEAVILY THROUGH HIS NOSE. From there he looks in room 4C. Smith's hands are strapped to the bed.

JOHN
(disappointed)
Is he tied up?

Angela nods empathically.

ANGELA
His attacks are getting more
frequent and more aggressive.

John rubs his forehead while he looks at Smith in room 4C. SIGHS DEEPLY in failure.

INT. MARIA HOSPITAL INTERNAL MEDICINE ROOM 4C

Carefully John walks into room 4C. Since we have last seen him, patient Smith has eaten his entire right hand and more bitemarks have developed on his legs. Inch by inch, Smith is slowly disappearing.

Smith slowly wakes up.

SMITH
(weak)
Doctor? I thought you had a day
off?

JOHN
That's right.
But I don't mind.
How are you feeling?

Smith smiles shyly.

SMITH

I am not sure, it feels like my legs are being smashed by hammer and it's starting to become unbearable, could you-.

JOHN

'Smashed by a hammer'? I thought you said the infection felt 'red hot'.

John quickly GRABS Smith's CHART.

SMITH

(suddenly awake)

Oh yeah, that's what I meant.

John looks unconvinced, frowns.

SMITH (CONT'D)

(childish, pathetic)

Could you please remove these ties, they are really uncomfortable.

JOHN

I'm sorry.
I can't do that.

SMITH

Please, I promise I won't do anything, I have an itch I *have* to scratch.

JOHN

(curt)

I wish you a pleasant evening.

John turns around. Smith explodes in anger, VIGOROUSLY PULLING his TIES and KICKING with his LEGS.

SMITH

(anger)

Untie me damn it! I ain't no beast, I demand respect!

John has to fight the urge to turn back.

INT. MARIA HOSPITAL LOBBY EXIT

Angela is walking towards the revolving doors.

JOHN (O.C.)

Angela! Angela wait!

Angela looks back. He runs up to her and stands before her.

JOHN (CONT'D)
Patient Smith can't have an
infection, it has to be a disorder,
a syndrome, a *delusion*.

ANGELA
A delusion? Which one?

JOHN
That's what I am going to find out.

ANGELA
Ain't that doctor Peters job of
neurology? It's his specialism
after all-.

JOHN
-.There is no time for that, I have
to help him *now*. His mind is
deteriorating as we speak. He will
continue to refuse help until he is
cured.

ANGELA
It's not your job John, you can't
do everything-.

JOHN
It's too late for that! He is
slowly disappearing before our eyes
and it is my fault for noticing
this now. I *need* to find answers!

Angela SIGHS.

ANGELA
Alright, I will help you.

John takes a step back.

JOHN
(surprised)
Oh, no, that's not what I meant-. I
will work on it-.

ANGELA
No. You get my help whether you
like it or not.
(stop)
But first, let's grab some food. I
am starving.

Angela WALKS towards the revolving doors while John is frozen of confusion. He unfreezes and runs after her.

INT. JOHNS HOME LIBRARY - NIGHT

Angela is sitting behind a laptop at a desk while John is sitting on the floor reading. Books about neurology, psychology, psychoanalysis lie among fast food wrappers.

ANGELA

John, Am I getting warmer with
"Fregoli delusion"?

John CHUCKLES while sitting on the floor.

JOHN

I read about that a few hours ago.
It's the phenomena where a person
thinks multiple people are in fact
one person in disguise. Like that
your mailmen, mother and *girlfriend*
are all the same person!

John LAUGHS. Angela GIGGLES. But her smile fades in a empathetic look while looking at John.

ANGELA

Where is Jane, by the way?

John looks up, but quickly buries his face back in his book.

JOHN

Oh Jane?
(stop)
Yeah, she is staying with her
parents for a few weeks.

Angela looks worried.

John turns to the last page of the medical book he's reading.
He frowns.

JOHN (CONT'D)

(frustrated)

I don't get it. Nowhere, not
anything, not even a mention. There
is no record of somebody ever
eating themselves.

ANGELA

Are you sure?

JOHN
This is the third time I read all
of the medical field that-.

John's PHONE RINGS that is laying on the floor. The two look
at each other in confusion because of the late hour call.
John PICKS UP.

JOHN (CONT'D)
(in phone)
This is John?

NURSE 1 (O.S.)
(phone, panick)
Patient Smith broke through his
ties and is brutally attacking
himself, he is in a critical state!
You have to come now doctor!

JOHN
(phone)
I will be right there.

John HANGS UP.
John starts running to the door.

JOHN (CONT'D)
We have to go back to the hospital,
Now!

Angela jumps up from her chair and grabs her coat.

INT. CAR

They drive to the hospital through the night in silence. John
is behind the steering wheel with a sleepy, almost catatonic
look on his face. His eyes fixated on the endless road.

JOHN (V.O.)
How have I let it come to this...

CUT TO:

INT. MARIA HOSPITAL INTERNAL MEDICINE ROOM 4C

A bloody bed, Smith laying on his back is THRASHING and
FIGHTING with two nurses.

HEARTMONITOR BEEPING FAST.

CUT TO:

INT. CAR

A dim light appears over the horizon.

JOHN (V.O.)
I missed all the signs...

The CAR slowly drifts to the left, onto the incoming traffic lane. In the distance the light appears to be that of a truck rushing closer.

JOHN (V.O.)
How dare I call myself a doctor?

CUT TO:

INT. MARIA HOSPITAL INTERNAL MEDICINE ROOM 4C

More nurses and security try to help and stop Smith.

HEARTMONITOR BEEPING FAST.
Smith spits blood from his mouth.

CUT TO:

INT. CAR

John closes his eyes slowly.

JOHN (V.O.)
I am nothing. And I deserve
everything.

The headlights of the oncoming truck become blinding.

ANGELA (O.C.)
John!

Finally ANGELA's VOICE breaks through John's thoughts. John escapes his trance. The LARGE TRUCK HONKS DEAFENINGLY. With great force and speed, John TURNS the car aside, merely missing the front of the truck. With SQUEAKING TIRES, John tries to get the car under control.

John STOPS the CAR ABRUPTLY on the side of the road with SQUEAKING TIRES. Angela flies forward, still in her seatbelt. John THROWS OPEN the DOOR. He sticks his head out of the side of the car. PUKE SPLASHES ON THE ASPHALT. Angela QUICKLY UNBUCKLES. She RUNS around the car to assist John.

JOHN
(dry heaving)
It's all my fault Angela, I killed
this man with my own incompetence.
It was the only thing I had left.
Jane has left me my career is
ruined!

ANGELA
That's not true...

(MORE)

JOHN
(tearful)
I am not allowed to be a doctor.

ANGELA
You're one of the best doctors who
stepped through those doors-...

Angela's voice starts to drown out in the BACKGROUND noise of
CARS DRIVING PAST and a RINGING in Dulken's ear.
John, never looking at Angela, stares at a half-eaten
roadkill beside the road.

INT. MARIA HOSPITAL INTERNAL MEDICINE ROOM 4C

It's dark in room 4C besides a reading lamp in the corner.
Smith lies motionless in his bed, hooked up to a HEARTMONITOR
which is CALMLY BEEPING. A muzzle has been strapped to his
face. His left arm and leg are chewed up to their bone, with
the bed covered with dark red blood.

Outside room 4C, John gestures to Angela to wait.

John carefully walks in, he's pale, puke stains on clothes,
acne covering his face, sweaty. He STEPS closer to the bed
and sees Smith's devoured arm and leg. All scars and
bitemarks on his body are visible of which there are many. He
sees all the damage done to it, of what is left of it.
John breaks down in tears, FALLS TO HIS knees.

JOHN
I'm so sorry, I am so sorry, it is
all my fault.

We slowly see the mutilated arm rise, though limited because
of the straps. A SOFT GROWL comes from the patient. John
looks up with tears in his eyes. Smith's eyes look back at
him.

SMITH
(weak)
...It is not your fault.

John looks confused at Smith.

JOHN
Why not? I failed at-.

SMITH
-.We are the same beast.
(cough)
An animal that never dares to
forgive itself.

JOHN
I'm sorry, I know I can do it, but
I want to do-.

SMITH
-"it as good as I possibly can"

Smith LAUGHS QUIETLY, COUGHS. The tip of a finger and some
blood falls out of the muzzle that is strapped to Smith's
face.

SMITH (CONT'D)
Every last one of us says that.

Johns eyes open wide as if he had seen a ghost.

SMITH (CONT'D)
I was exactly like you, I lost my
head, and with that my job, my
friends.... and my sweet Lisa.
All because of the pressure I laid
on myself...

Smith closes his eyes and shakes his head.

SMITH (CONT'D)
I hated myself so much that I
wanted to eat myself, until nothing
was left of me. Not only because I
wouldn't be able to hurt anybody
else, but it was also the most
painful way to go...

JOHN
Why are you telling me this now? I
could've helped you.

SMITH

I don't want help! That's why I
lied about my symptoms. Lure you
away from my real intention

Smith has a harsh COUGHING FIT. More dead and half devoured
skin flies from his throat. John STANDS UP in fury.

JOHN

You lied! If you didn't lie you
would be alive and well right now.

Smith looks at John with an evil smile.

SMITH

And you did not lie? Constantly
refusing help? Downplaying you were
crumbling under the pressure? Not
wanting to seem *weak*.

John looks at the ground, SIGHS in shame.
He lays his hand on his head and leans on the bed.

SMITH (CONT'D)

We aren't so different, you and I,
John. You are eating yourself
too...

SMITH (CONT'D)

Our methods may be different, but
our results will be fatal.

John SWALLOWS DEEP. He looks at the ground. Then slowly turns
to Angela, who looks back at him through the window.
John smiles carefully and turns back at Smith. He takes a
DEEP BREATH.

John comes closer to Smith.
John walks besides the bed, RELEASING the BELT from the
patient's arm. The HEARTMONITOR starts to BEEP QUICKER and
QUICKER.

JOHN

Then it's time for me to change my
method...

He takes off the MUZZLE from Smith's face. Smith is looking
up at John in confusion and angst. He away from Smith towards
the entrance. John doesn't look back at Smith and DROPS the
MUZZLE on the floor.

INT. MARIA HOSPITAL INTERNAL MEDICINE UNIT

Angela is standing in the middle of the dark hall.

John walks out of room 4C and with Angela they walk away.
Smith looks at his mutilated body and back to John, with a
frightened and regretful look on his face through the window.

FADE TO BLACK.

THE END